

Shaheen Mistri

Shaheen Mistri (born 1967, age 59) founded Teach For India in 2009, building India's largest educational leadership movement recruiting 4,000+ Fellows who've taught 160,000+ low-income students while creating 5,500+ alumni leaders transforming education systems.

Education

- Bachelor's degree from University of Manchester, UK, focusing on social sciences and development studies

Career

Started Akanksha Foundation in 1989 at age 18 after returning to India from studies abroad, shocked by educational disparities in Mumbai slums. Ran volunteer-led after-school centers serving 200 children initially, scaling to 25 centers impacting 5,000+ students by 2008 with innovative pedagogy focused on critical thinking, values, and joyful learning—model studied by educators globally.

In 2007-2008, partnered with McKinsey to study replicability, meeting Teach For America founder Wendy Kopp which sparked Teach For India vision. Launched TFI in 2009 with 78 Fellows in Mumbai/Pune after securing seed funding from Tata Trusts, HDFC, and individual philanthropists. Simultaneously grew Akanksha (now operates independently with 6,500 students in 20 centers) while building TFI infrastructure.

Serves on global education boards including Teach For All, co-founded by Wendy Kopp to scale TFI model in 60+ countries. Advocate for National Education Policy reforms, teacher autonomy, and equity-first curriculum.

Awards and Recognition

- Ashoka Fellow (1992), among India's youngest Fellows recognized for Akanksha's scalable impact on education
- Asia Society's Asia Game Changer Award (2015) for transforming educational access across India
- Schwab Foundation Social Entrepreneur of the Year (multiple recognitions)
- Youth Icon Award by various institutions; featured in Fortune India's "Most Powerful Women in Business"
- Ramon Magsaysay Award nominee; speaker at World Economic Forum, TEDx platforms on educational equity

Shaheen Mistry's Story

At 18, during Tufts University summer break, Shaheen visited Mumbai grandparents and was shocked by slum inequity. Dropped out of college, joined St. Xavier's, and met Sandhya who opened her home as makeshift classroom—Akanksha's start.



Nineteen principals rejected her before Holy Convent School accepted. First center (1989) had 40 children; volunteers taught via games, not rote methods. Running Akanksha 17 years revealed volunteer model limits—needed full-time teachers for systemic change.

Meeting Wendy Kopp sparked TFI vision: recruit top graduates as teachers, build leadership pipeline. Skeptics doubted IIT/IIM grads would teach for low pay; first cohort proved them wrong with 2,500 applicants for 78 slots. COVID pivot in 2020 shifted to phone-based teaching and community pods, distributing 50,000+ grocery kits while maintaining student engagement.

Leadership at Teach For India

As Founder-CEO, Shaheen built India's most selective education Fellowship: 120,000+ applicants over 15 years, 970+ current Fellows teaching 32,000+ students across 8 cities. Columbia University study showed TFI students achieved 5x growth in English, 2.5x in Math vs. non-TFI classrooms.

Created 5,500+ alumni ecosystem—77% continue in social sector, founded 160+ ventures, hold NITI Aayog/state policy positions. Initiatives include TFIx (rural Fellowships Bihar to J&K), Firki teacher portal, Maya Musical student leadership program. Secured funding from Tata Trusts, HDFC Bank; students placed at UWC, U Chicago, IITs, Ashoka University.

Her philosophy: build movement, not just organization—leaders who transform education from within as teachers, principals, policymakers, entrepreneurs. Excellent education is a right, not privilege.